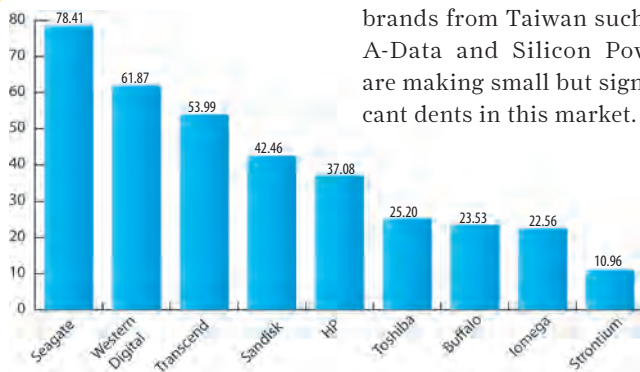




External Storage

With the explosion of downloadable media (a.k.a piracy), the external drive market has been growing at an alarmingly high rate just to keep up with the terabytes of content data hoarders now have access to. The category had the highest percentage of multiple devices owned by individual respondents. About 22 per cent of all devices were secondary devices. A small fraction of the audience could even be certified storage junkies owning as many



as six different brands of storage devices.

A lot happened during the year: those mammoths that required external power fell out of fashion and high

capacity hard drives (1 TB plus) became even more portable, brands went for rugged and stylish designs, and there emerged newer technologies. We're talking about USB 3.0 becoming mainstream. The new standard has a theoretical transfer rate of 5 Gbps as opposed to the theoretical speeds of 480 Mbps offered by USB 2.0.

Although the actual hard drives within the stylish cases are manufactured by only a handful of players, such as WD, Seagate and Samsung, the external hard drive market has a wide variety of names. Many brands from Taiwan such as A-Data and Silicon Power are making small but significant dents in this market. So

despite all the breadth we knew the battle would only be between Western Digital and Seagate. Once we tabulated scores, ran our calculations, Seagate emerged as the most

trusted brand for external storage. But what surprised us was the lead it had over WD. Seagate scored 78.37 percent while Western Digital came in a distant second at 62.18 percent.

Key findings:

1. Some brand names such as Freeagent from Seagate were more popular amongst respondents with a few people responding with the brand name instead of the companies associated with the brand.
2. A surprising entry at the number five spot on our Trust Index was HP. Though HP drives may not be commonly purchased over the counter, their market penetration seems to be pretty high (about 6 percent), perhaps owing to bundled deals with their other products.
3. Close to half the respondents (47.75 percent) owned Seagate drives followed by WD (15.73 percent) and Transcend (15.73 percent).
4. The least known brand amongst the respondents was Strontium. It scored the lowest on our aided recall question and respondents consistently chose the "nothing to

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say" option for this brand on all questions.

5. In most of the parameters such as Loyalty, Credibility, Awareness etc the scores mirrored the ranking order of brands on the Trust Index except for Availability. In terms of availability Transcend came in second after Seagate.

6. Votes for the Satisfaction parameter significantly contributed to the scores of the two top runners thanks to their strong RMA support and warranty periods. However, a recent update states that both Seagate and WD have slashed their warranties to one and two years instead of the previous period of three and five year periods.



GPUs

Since time immemorial, the GPU arena has always been polarised into two factions. The two chipset designers – AMD and NVIDIA – wage war on each other for market supremacy while vendors such as ASUS,

MSI, ZOTAC etc can be thought of as the facilitators of this battle. This has been the playingfield for the longest time and the rules change very little every year. The chip makers try to outdo each other on a couple of parameters namely, price and speed. Ultimately the card that produces

